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Cassette's new app
turns your videos into
retro, VHS-like home
movies

CASSETTE

Sarah Perez — 8:26 AM PDT · August 12, 2025

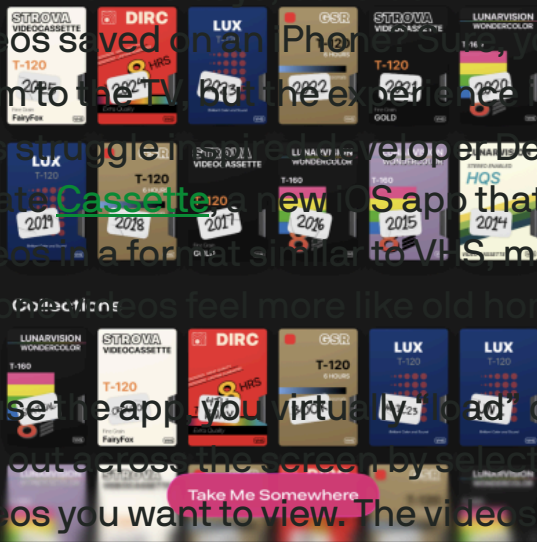
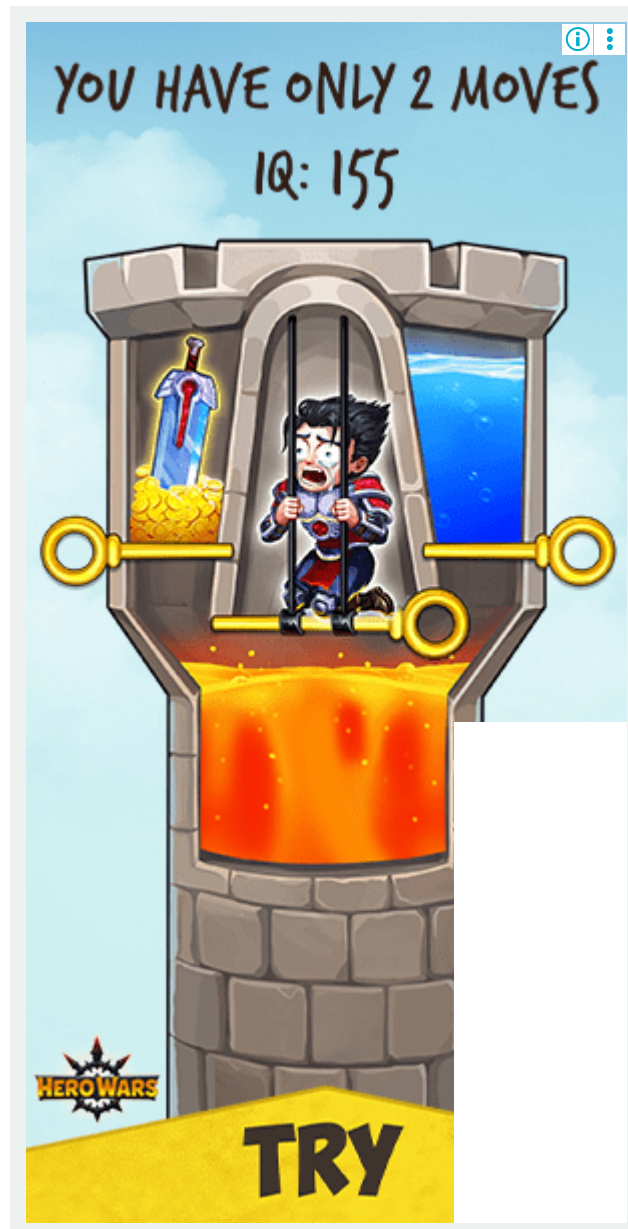


IMAGE CREDITS: CASSETTE

You can then watch your life unfold on the screen with no further interaction required on your part.



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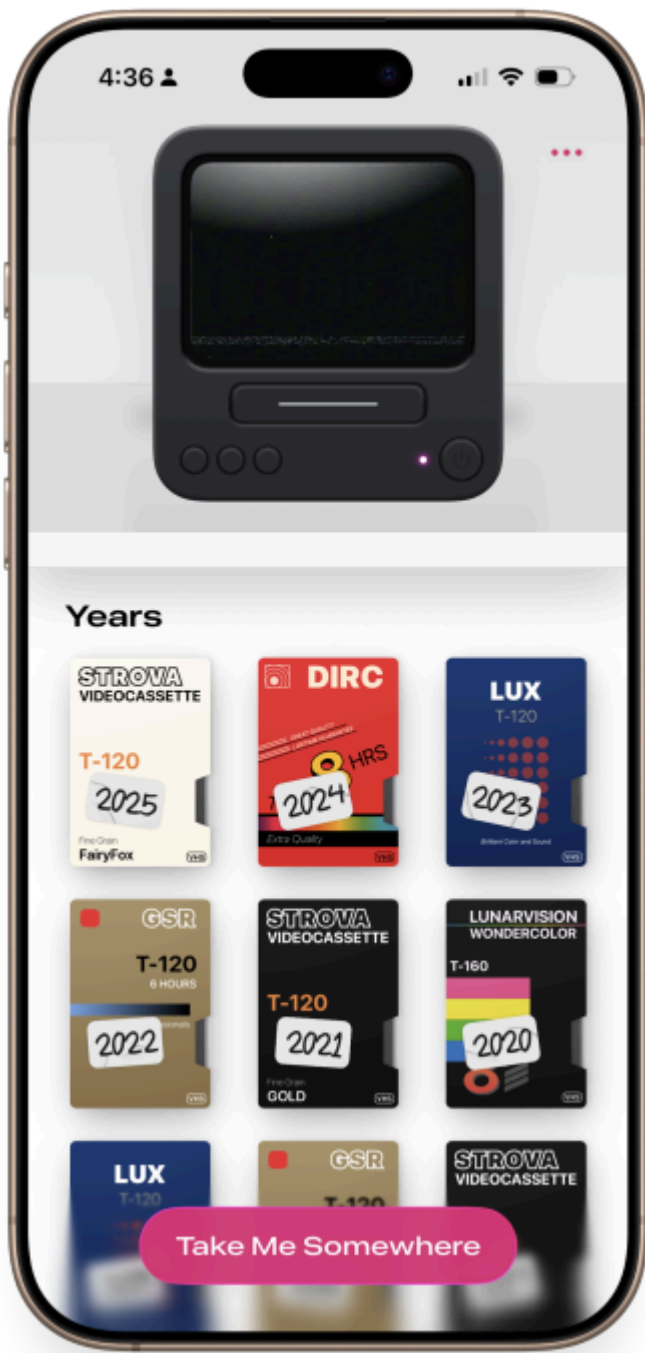


IMAGE CREDITS: CASSETTE

This lean-back experience introduces a new way to consume the media you have saved on your device, which is often left unviewed after the initial recording.

The idea for Cassette was prompted by Davies' friend and fellow app developer [Charlie Chapman](#), who is also a senior advocate at RevenueCat, a platform that helps mobile app developers manage in-app purchases and subscriptions. Chapman complained in a group chat about how watching home movies as a family today just wasn't the same as it used to be when watching old family videotapes.

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He said he wished there was a way to AirPlay videos to the TV and then have them immediately play one after the other.

Davies, best known for his [award-winning](#) recipe app [Crouton](#), jumped on the idea, hacking together Cassette from a custom slideshow app he had made for Apple TV. He later shared a test build with the group chat.

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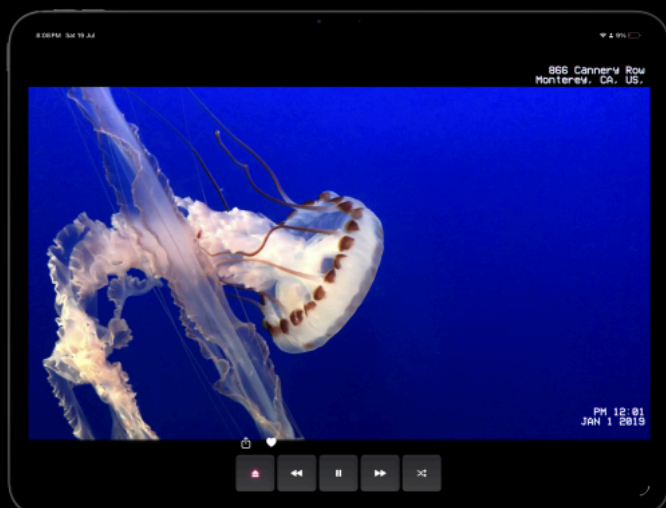
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A new way to watch
your home videos
like the old way



“I kid you not, the entire group chat had this profound experience with our partners where we stayed up all night watching our kids grow up before our eyes,” Chapman told TechCrunch. “I’ve never experienced ‘product market fit,’ or whatever you want to call it, like this before,” he said.

The app itself offers a clever and simple design, where you’re presented with rows of VHS tapes, in all their retro splendor. You tap on one to virtually “load” it into the TV icon at the top of the iPhone’s screen to start playing the video. With AirPlay, you can also mirror your device to a TV to watch the full experience play out on the big screen.

The videos themselves include a location, date, and timestamp displayed in a retro pixel font that looks like the old screen fonts used on VHS tapes. (Even if you’re too young to remember VHS tapes, seeing old videos in this format pulls on the heartstrings. That could be because old home movies are still regularly referenced in modern movies and TV shows during sentimental moments and scenes.)

In practice, there were some challenges that the app still needs to overcome.

If you have a habit of downloading online videos, like TikToks or Reels, these will show up among your “home movies.” However, Davies tells TechCrunch that the app is already filtering out screen recordings, and he’s now looking to see if TikTok videos could be filtered out, too.

To support its development, Cassette offers an optional premium subscription (dubbed “ColorPlus”) that allows users to manually select a VHS tape instead of having the app play a video at random. This costs either \$0.99 per month or \$5.99 per year. There’s also an affordable Lifetime unlock

for \$7.99, which can go a long way toward supporting indie projects like this.

The app is a [free download for iPhone and iPad](#).

Topics: [Apps](#) [Cassette](#) [indie apps](#) [iOS apps](#)



Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor |

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Substack writers can now direct US readers to (often cheaper) web-based subscriptions on iOS

Newsletter subscription platform Substack will begin taking advantage of an option on the U.S. App Store that allows users to make purchases outside of Apple's in-app purchasing system. This functionality is permitted by a [change to the App Store's rules in May](#), as a result of [Epic Games' antitrust lawsuit](#) against the tech giant.

Since then, a number of top apps have moved to offer in-app purchase links that point to their own websites, including [Spotify](#), [Patreon](#), and the [Amazon Kindle](#) app, among others.

In Substack's case, support for external payments will benefit both the company, which no longer has to pay the App Store a commission on those web sales, and consumers, who will have access to reduced pricing. Meanwhile, Substack creators will be able to offer their readers the option of whether they want the convenience of Apple's in-app payments system (IAP) or the web payment option, which is now accessible without having to leave the app.

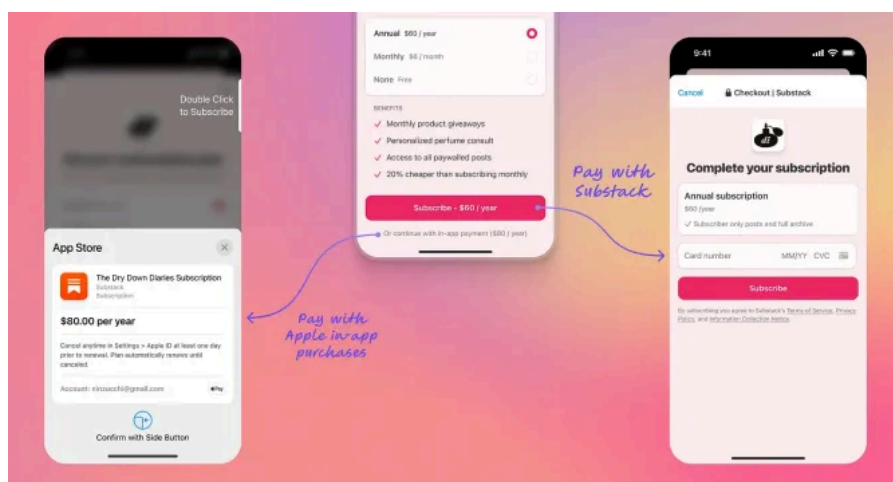
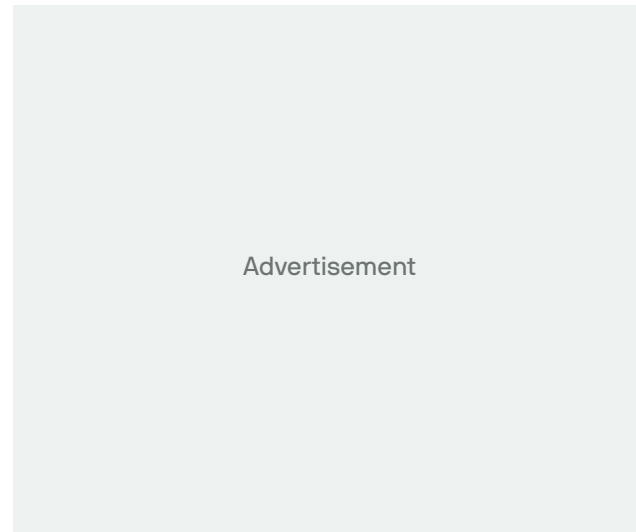


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK



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Substack explains it will automatically adjust its customers' iOS app price higher to account for Apple's fees, allowing creators to take home the same amount of money as a web subscription. However, Substack writers can disable this feature if they choose. (Substack will continue to take its own 10% fee based on the web subscription price, as before.)

The company said in its blog post that it's also offering its writers "migration tools." We originally reported that these could help migrate users from one payments platform to another, but Substack reached out to correct this. Instead, it said that the tools are meant to help creators access billing information for Apple-managed subscriptions if they ever leave the platform.

Currently, more than 30,000 publications on the platform have in-app purchases enabled; Substack says early tests of the expanded set of payment options have driven a boost in paid sign-ups. It did not, however, share specific numbers related to this.

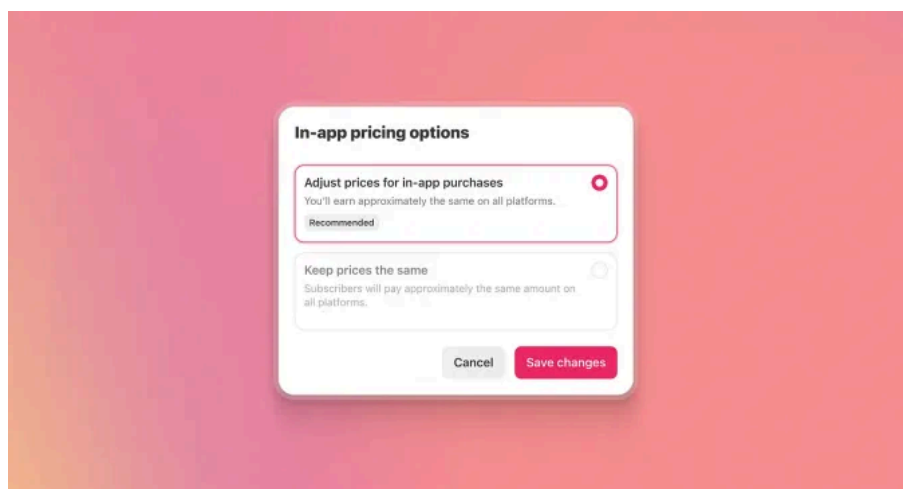


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

The public launch of the external payments option will only impact new Substack subscriptions. Substack writers don't have to take any action unless they want to lower the prices for those using Apple's payments system.

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Per Apple’s App Store rules, fully opting out of offering IAP is not allowed.

While the changes impact the Substack app in the U.S., the company says it’s still evaluating if it makes sense to switch to the more complex rules Apple offers in the EU and U.K. for developers who want to forgo IAP.

Updated after publication to correct and clarify how the migration tools work.

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X's declining Android app installs are hurting subscription revenue

Sarah Perez — 1:49 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

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sharp drop in Android downloads, which were then down by nearly half (49%) year-over-year.



Sarah Perez - 6 hours ago

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OpenAI launches a sub-\$5 ChatGPT plan in India

Ivan Mehta - 12 hours ago

New X Downloads on Mobile by Month

Estimated Downloads • Worldwide • App Store and Google Play



IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

The firm didn't speculate on what's causing the decline on Android devices beyond suggesting that the X app on Android is known to be a sore spot for the company. Recently hired [X head of product Nikita Bier](#), known for growth hacking teen social apps like [Gas](#) and [TBH](#) (then [selling them](#)), has hinted that X is looking to address issues on Android, where its app is [notoriously buggy](#) and [often crashes](#).

In a post on the platform, Bier [announced](#) that X was hiring for its "Android Dream Team" to work on rebuilding the X Android app. He also recently posted that X's iOS app [had just seen a record week in terms of installs](#), perhaps hoping to draw attention away from the large Android slump.

New X Downloads on Mobile by Month with Year-Over-Year Growth

Estimated Downloads • Worldwide • App Store and Google Play

Month	App Store	YoY	Google Play	YoY	Unified	YoY
Jan-24	2,963,000	-	6,303,000	-	9,266,000	-
Feb-24	3,623,000	-	6,352,000	-	9,975,000	-
Mar-24	3,363,000	-	6,689,000	-	10,052,000	-
Apr-24	2,971,000	-	7,536,000	-	10,507,000	-
May-24	2,993,000	-	7,676,000	-	10,669,000	-
Jun-24	3,514,000	-	8,787,000	-	12,301,000	-
Jul-24	3,429,000	-	7,742,000	-	11,171,000	-
Aug-24	3,338,000	-	7,953,000	-	11,291,000	-
Sep-24	2,679,000	-	6,347,000	-	9,026,000	-
Oct-24	2,876,000	-	5,895,000	-	8,771,000	-
Nov-24	2,629,000	-	5,735,000	-	8,364,000	-
Dec-24	2,691,000	-	5,861,000	-	8,552,000	-
Jan-25	3,312,000	12%	6,019,000	-5%	9,331,000	1%
Feb-25	3,475,000	-4%	5,535,000	-13%	9,010,000	-10%
Mar-25	3,359,000	0%	6,814,000	2%	10,173,000	1%
Apr-25	3,029,000	2%	5,032,000	-33%	8,061,000	-23%
May-25	3,370,000	13%	4,766,000	-38%	8,136,000	-24%
Jun-25	3,531,000	0%	4,451,000	-49%	7,982,000	-35%
Jul-25	3,950,000	15%	4,334,000	-44%	8,284,000	-26%

Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

It’s not clear where would-be X Android users are going. Rival Bluesky has seen slowing growth in recent months, and its Google Play app pulled in just 119,000 downloads in July. That’s nowhere near the millions that install X on iOS or Android every month. However, Meta’s Threads daily active users have been [catching up to X on mobile devices](#), so, possibly, some Android users could be accounted for there.

In addition to the drop in Google Play installs, X is struggling to grow its subscription revenue, Appfigures found.

In July, X earned \$16.9 million in net revenue, down from the \$18.8 million it earned in March 2025. However, that was a slight tick up from the \$16.8 million it generated in June. (Of course, X still earns the majority of its overall revenue from ads, not in-app premium subscriptions.)

While the declining demand for X on Android is partially to blame for revenue declines, X is also

likely losing paying customers to Grok. The latter now has its own [stand-alone app](#) that attracts those who were buying X subscriptions primarily for the AI perks.

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Hank Green's Focus Friend app is climbing the App Store charts — and it's extremely cute

Amanda Silberling — 10:36 AM PDT · August 18, 2025



You must stay focused. You cannot open TikTok, or Instagram, or whatever little phone games you like to play. If you fail, you will make an anthropomorphic bean very sad, because its knitting project depends on your ability to stay focused.

IMAGE CREDITS: FOCUS FRIEND

This is the premise of [Focus Friend](#), a productivity app created by [Honey B Games](#) and [Hank Green](#), the longtime online creator/entrepreneur/educator/[sock salesman](#). Though the app was soft launched last month, Focus Friend is only now gaining momentum on the App Store charts — likely because Green and his brother, author John Green, are [posting about it more](#) — reaching No. 4 among all free apps and No. 2 among productivity apps.

[@hankgreen1](#)

Your Deserve a Focus Friend

[🎵 original sound – Hank Green](#)

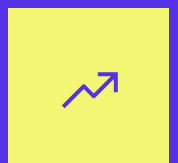
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Focus Friend, which is available on [iOS](#) and [Android](#), has the bones of a typical productivity app. It invites you to set a timer on your phone, which will temporarily prevent you from opening certain apps (on iOS, the “Deep Focus Mode” setting connects to your own screen time settings, where you can designate which apps to block).

But what makes Focus Friend different is that it assigns you a new friend — a little bean — which you can give a cute name, like Garbanzo, or Susan Bean Anthony, or Eda (it’s short for Edamame).

Your bean needs help focusing on its knitting. And it can only focus if you refrain from opening the apps that distract you from your work. If you successfully complete your focus session, your bean will give you in-game points (socks), which you can use to buy decorations for its room — because the only thing more motivating than helping a bean knit is to buy it a cute poster for its wall.

Focus Friend has a lot in common with [Finch](#), a popular self-care app that incentivizes users to maintain healthy habits by giving them a virtual bird companion. Your bird grows when you complete certain tasks that you set for yourself, like drinking water, brushing your teeth, or cleaning your room. Like the Tamagotchis of yore, these apps exploit our desire to protect a cute bundle of pixels by doing stuff that’s good for us.

Focus Friend is functional as a free app, but you can pay to give your bean different skins — you can make your bean look like a cat (a “Kitt-ney Bean”) or a jelly bean, for example. There’s also a subscription that allows your bean to knit scarves, which can be exchanged for premium decorations. Green [posted](#) on Bluesky that Focus Friend is “very much trying to be an ad-free experience because the mobile ad ecosystem kinda blows.” But the app still has to

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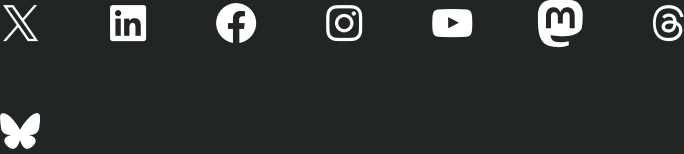
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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She has also...

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